Mr. Big

By Woody Allen

KAISER: I was sitting in my office, cleaning the debris out of my .38 and wondering where my next case was coming from. I like being a private eye, and even though once in a while I've had my gums massaged with an automobile jack, the sweet smell of greenbacks makes it all worth it. Not to mention the dames, which are a minor preoccupation of mine that I rank just ahead of breathing. That's why, when the door to my office swung open and a long-haired blonde named Heather Butkiss came striding in and told me she needed my help, my salivary glands shifted into third.

INTRODUCTION

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KAISER: "What can I do for you, sugar?"

HEATHER/CLAIRE/ELLEN: "I want you to find someone for me, Mr. Lupowitz."

KAISER: "Call me Kaiser, sugar. All right, so what's the scam?"

HEATHER/CLAIRE/ELLEN: "God. The Creator, the Underlying Principle, the First Cause of Things, the All Encompassing. I want you to find Him for me."

KAISER: "Why?"

HEATHER/CLAIRE/ELLEN: "That's my business, Kaiser. You just find Him."

KAISER: "I'm sorry, sugar. You got the wrong boy."

HEATHER/CLAIRE/ELLEN: "But why?"

KAISER: "Unless I know all the facts," I said, rising.

HEATHER/CLAIRE/ELLEN: "O.K., O.K.," she said, biting her lower lip.

KAISER: She straightened the seam of her stocking, which was strictly for my benefit, but I wasn't buying any at the moment. "Let's have it on the line, sugar."

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HEATHER/CLAIRE/ELLEN: My name is not Heather Butkiss, either. It's Claire Rosensweig and I'm a student at Vassar. Philosophy major. History of Western Thought and all that. I have a paper due January. On Western religion. All the other kids in the course will hand in speculative papers. But I want to know. Professor Grebanier said if anyone finds out for sure, they're a cinch to pass the course. And my dad's promised me a Mercedes if! get straight Xs."

KAISER: I opened a deck of Luckies and a pack of gum and had one of each. Her story was beginning to interest me. Spoiled coed. High IQ and a body I wanted to know better. "What does God look like?"

HEATHER/CLAIRE/ELLEN: "I've never seen Him."

KAISER: "Well, how do you know He exists?"

HEATHER/CLAIRE/ELLEN: "That's for you to find out."

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KAISER: "Oh, great. Then you don't know what He looks like? Or where to begin looking?"

HEATHER/CLAIRE/ELLEN: "No. Not really. Although I suspect He's everywhere. In the air, in every flower, in you and I-and in this chair." "Vh-huh."

KAISER: So she was a pantheist. I made a mental note of it and said I'd give her case a try-for a hundred bucks a day, expenses, and a dinner date. She smiled and O.K.'d the deal. We rode down in the elevator together. Outside it was getting dark. Maybe God did exist and maybe He didn't, but somewhere in that city there were sure a lot of guys who were going to try and keep me from finding out. My first lead was Rabbi Itzhak Wiseman, a local cleric who owed me a favor for finding out who was rubbing pork on his hat. I knew something was wrong when I spoke to him because he was scared. Real scared.

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WISEMAN: "Of course there's a you-know-what, but I'm not even allowed to say His name or He'll strike me dead, which I could never understand why someone is so touchy aboUt having his name said."

KAISER: "You ever see Him?"

WISEMAN: "Me? Are you kidding? I'm lucky I get to see my grandchildren."

KAISER: "Then how do you know He exists?"

WISEMAN: "How do I know? What kind of question is that? Could I get a suit like this for fourteen dollars if there was no one up there? Here, feel a gabardine-how can you doubt?"

KAISER: "You got nothing more to go on?"

WISEMAN: "Hey-what's the Old Testament? Chopped liver? How do you think Moses got the Israelites out of Egypt? With a smile and a tap dance? Believe me, you don't part the Red Sea with some gismo from Korvette's. It takes power."

KAISER: "So He's tough, eh?"

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WISEMAN: "Yes. Very tough. You'd think with all that success He'd be a lot sweeter."

KAISER: "How come you know so much?"

WISEMAN: "Because we're the chosen people. He takes best care of us of all His children, which I'd also like to someday discuss with Him."

KAISER: "What do you pay Him for being chosen?"

WISEMAN: "Don't ask."

KAISER: So that's how it was. The Jews were into God for a lot. It was the old protection racket. Take care of them in return for a price. And from the way Rabbi Wiseman was talking, He soaked them plenty. I got into a cab and made it over to Danny's Billiards on Tenth Avenue. The manager was a slimy little guy I didn't like. Chicago Phil. Forger, bank robber, strong-arm man, and avowed atheist.

CHICAGO PHIL: "The guy never existed, Kaiser. This is the straight dope. It's a big hype. There's no Mr. Big. It's a syndicate. Mostly Sicilian. It's

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international. But there is no actual head. Except maybe the Pope."

KAISER: "I want to meet the Pope."

CHICAGO PHIL: "It can be arranged," he said, winking.

KAISER: "Does the name Claire Rosensweig mean anything to you?"

CHICAGO PHIL: "No."

KAISER: "Heather Butkiss?"

CHICAGO PHIL: "Oh, wait a minute. Sure. She's that peroxide job with the bazooms from Radcliffe."

KAISER: "Radcliffe? She told me Vassar."

CHICAGO PHIL: "Well, she's lying. She's a teacher at Radcliffe. She was mixed up with a philosopher for a while."

KAISER: "Pantheist?"

CHICAGO PHIL: "No. Empiricist, as I remember. Bad guy. Completely rejected Hegel or any dialectical methodology."

KAISER: "One of those."

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CHICAGO PHIL: "Yeah. He used to be a drummer with a jazz trio. Then he got hooked on logical positivism. When that didn't work, he tried pragmatism. Last I heard he stole a lot of money to take a course in Schopenhauer at Columbia. The mob would like to find him-or get their hands on his textbooks so they can resell them."

KAISER: "Thanks, Phil."

CHICAGO PHIL: "Take it from me, Kaiser. There's no one out there. It's a void. I couldn't pass all those bad checks or screw society the way I do if for one second I was able to recognize any authentic sense of Being. The universe is strictly phenomenological. Nothing's eternal. It's all meaningless."

KAISER: I had a beer at O'Rourke's and tried to add it all up, but it made no sense at all. Socrates was a suicide-or so they said. Christ was murdered. Nietzsche went nuts. If there was someone out there, He sure as hell didn't

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want anybody to know it. And why was Claire Rosensweig lying about Vassar? Could Descartes have been right? Was the universe dualistic? Or did Kant hit it on the head when he postulated the existence of God on moral grounds? Then the phone rang. The voice on the other end was Sergeant Reed of Homicide.

SERGEANT REED: "You still looking for God?"

KAISER: "Yeah."

SERGEANT REED: ''An all-powerful Being? Great Oneness, Creator of the Universe? First Cause of All Things?"

KAISER: "That's right."

SERGEANT REED: "Somebody with that description just showed up at the morgue. You better get down here right away."

KAISER: It was Him all right, and from the looks of Him it was a professional job.

SERGEANT REED: "He was dead when they brought Him in."

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KAISER: "Where'd you find Him?"

SERGEANT REED: ''A warehouse on Delancey Street."

KAISER: ''Any dues?"

SERGEANT REED: "It's the work of an existentialist. We're sure of that."

KAISER: "How can you te11?"

SERGEANT REED: "Haphazard way how it was done. Doesn't seem to be any system followed. Impulse."

KAISER: ''A crime of passion?"

SERGEANT REED: "You got it. Which means you're a suspect, Kaiser."

KAISER: "Why me?"

SERGEANT REED: "Everybody down at headquarters knows how you feel about Jaspers."

KAISER: "That doesn't make me a killer."

SERGEANT REED: "Not yet, but you're a suspect."

KAISER: Outside on the street I sucked air into my lungs and tried to dear my head. I took a cab over to Newark and got out and walked a block to Giordino's Italian Restaurant. There,

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at a back table, was His Holiness. It was the Pope, all right. Sitting with tWo guys I had seen in half a dozen police lineups. : "Sit down," he said, looking up from his fettuccine. He held out a ring. I gave him my toothiest smile but didn't kiss it. It bothered him and I was glad. Point for me.

THE POPE: "Would you like some fettuccine?"

KAISER: "No thanks, Holiness. But you go ahead."

THE POPE: "Nothing? Not even a salad?"

KAISER: "I just ate."

THE POPE: "Suit yourself, but they make a great Roquefort dressing here. Not like at the Vatican, where you can't get a decent meal."

KAISER: "I'll come right to the point, Pontiff. I'm looking for God."

THE POPE: "You came to the right person."

KAISER: "Then He does exist?" They all found this very amusing and laughed. The hood next to me said, "Oh, that's funny. Bright boy wants to know if He exists." I shifted my chair to

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get comfortable and brought the leg down on his little toe. "Sorry." But he was steaming.

THE POPE: "Sure He exists, Lupowitz, but I'm the only one that communicates with Him. He speaks only through me."

KAISER: "Why you, pal?"

THE POPE: "Because I got the red suit."

KAISER: "This get-up?"

THE POPE: "Don't knock it. Every morning I rise, put on this red suit, and suddenly I'm a big cheese. It's all in the suit. I mean, face it, if I went around in slacks and a sports jacket, I couldn't get arrested religion-wise."

KAISER: "Then it's a hype. There's no God."

THE POPE: "I don't know. But what's the difference? The money's good."

KAISER: "You ever worry the laundry won't get your red suit back on time and you'll be like the rest of us?"

THE POPE: "I use the special one-day service. I figure it's worth the extra few cents to be safe."

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KAISER: "Name Claire Rosensweig mean anything to you?"

THE POPE: "Sure. She's in the science department at Bryn Mawr."

KAISER: "Science, you say? Thanks."

THE POPE: "For what?"

KAISER: "The answer, Pontiff" I grabbed a cab and shot over the George Washington Bridge. On the way I stopped at my office and did some fast checking. Driving to Claire's apartment, I put the pieces together, and for the first time they fit. When I got there something seemed to be troubling her.

HEATHER/CLAIRE/ELLEN: "God is dead. The police were here. They're looking for you. They think an existentialist did it."

KAISER: "No, sugar. It was you."

HEATHER/CLAIRE/ELLEN: "What? Don't make jokes, Kaiser."

KAISER: "It was you that did it."

HEATHER/CLAIRE/ELLEN: "What are you saying?"

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KAISER: "You, baby. Not Heather Butkiss or Claire Rosensweig, but Dr. Ellen Shepherd."

HEATHER/CLAIRE/ELLEN: "How did you know my name?"

KAISER: "Professor of physics at Bryn Mawr. The youngest one ever to head a department there. At the midwinter Hop you get stuck on a jazz musician who's heavily into philosophy. He's married, but that doesn't stop you. A couple of nights and it feels like love. But it doesn't work out because something comes between you. God. Y'see, sugar, he believed, or wanted to, but you, with your pretty little scientific mind, had to have absolute certainty."

HEATHER/CLAIRE/ELLEN: "No, Kaiser, I swear."

KAISER: "So you pretend to study philosophy because that gives you a chance to eliminate certain obstacles. You get rid of Socrates easy enough, but Descartes takes over, so you use Spinoza to get rid of Descartes, but when

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Kant doesn't come through you have to get rid of him too."

HEATHER/CLAIRE/ELLEN: "You don't know what you're saying."

KAISER: "You made mincemeat out of Leibniz, but that wasn't good enough for you because you knew if anybody believed Pascal you were dead, so he had to be gotten rid of too, but that's where you made your mistake because you trusted Martin Buber. Except, sugar, he was soft. He believed in God, so you had to get rid of God yourself."

HEATHER/CLAIRE/ELLEN: "Kaiser, you're mad!"

KAISER: "No, baby. You posed as a pantheist and that gave you access to Him-if He existed, which he did. He went with you to Shelby's party and when Jason wasn't looking, you killed Him."

HEATHER/CLAIRE/ELLEN: "Who the hell are Shelby and Jason?"

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KAISER: "What's the difference? Life's absurd now anyway."

HEATHER/CLAIRE/ELLEN: "Kaiser," she said, suddenly trembling. "You wouldn't turn me in?"

KAISER: "Oh yes, baby. When the Supreme Being gets knocked off, somebody's got to take the rap."

HEATHER/CLAIRE/ELLEN: "Oh, Kaiser, we could go away together. Just the two of us. We could forget about philosophy. Settle down and maybe get into semantics."

KAISER: "Sorry, sugar. It's no dice." She was all tears now. A Venus whose right hand tousled my hair while her left hand had picked up a .45 and was holding it behind my back. I let go with a slug from my .38 before she could pull the trigger, and she dropped her gun and doubled over in disbelief.

HEATHER/CLAIRE/ELLEN: "How could you, Kaiser?"

KAISER: She was fading fast, but I managed to get it in, in time. "The manifestation of the universe as a complex idea unto itself as

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opposed to being in or outside the true Being of itself is inherently a conceptual nothingness or Nothingness in relation to any abstract form of existing or to exist or having existed in perpetuity and not subject to laws of physicality or motion or ideas relating to non-matter or the lack of objective Being or subjective otherness." It was a subtle concept but I think she understood before she died.

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AWARD HISTORY

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